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ChatIPO: Quick take on OpenAI's record-breaking IPO plans

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Authors

Adrian Cox
Research Analyst

Putting a giant share sale in context

The news that OpenAI is preparing to file for an initial public offering very shortly suggests that the maker of ChatGPT aims to strike while the iron is hot.

The poster child for AI plans to make a confidential filing with regulators as soon as tomorrow and aims to go public as early as September, the Wall Street Journal reported late yesterday, citing people familiar with the matter.

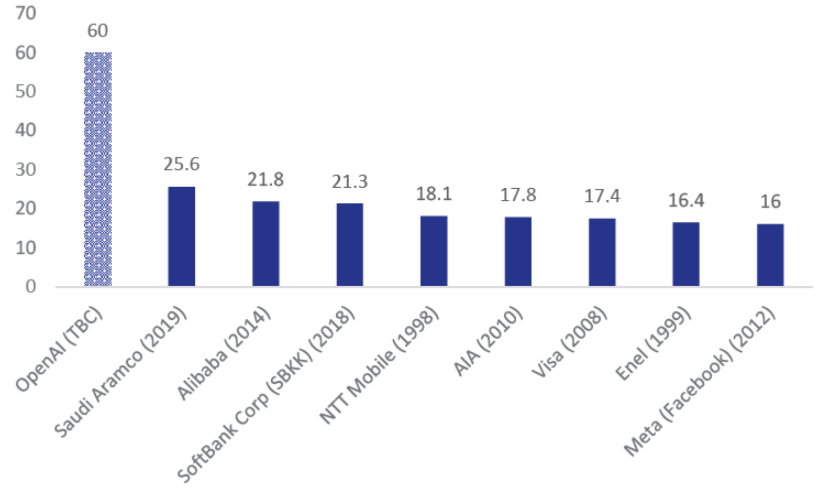
With an anticipated surge in IPOs this year, including of its fast-growing rival Anthropic, there will be a scramble to make the most of investor appetite for direct exposure to pure-play AI companies in the public markets.

Retail investors currently have to pick companies with AI offerings in other parts of the supply chain, either in infrastructure, such as semiconductor makers or cloud providers, or applications that sit on top of the foundation models. Shares in the Magnificent Seven tech companies have quadrupled since OpenAI launched ChatGPT on November 30, 2022.

OpenAI was valued at $852bn after completing its latest funding round at the end of March. Reports have suggested it could be planning to raise $60bn in an IPO that would value it at more than $1trn. That would be the biggest IPO ever, twice as big as Saudi Aramco's IPO, which was valued at $25.6bn in 2019, assuming no one else gets there first.

Even so, it has yet to be seen how public markets will value OpenAI and its peers once they open up their financial statements to scrutiny and explain the still little-understood economics of their business models.

Figure 1: A $60bn IPO would be more than double Saudi Aramco's record ($bn)



Source: Investopedia, media reports, Deutsche Bank Research

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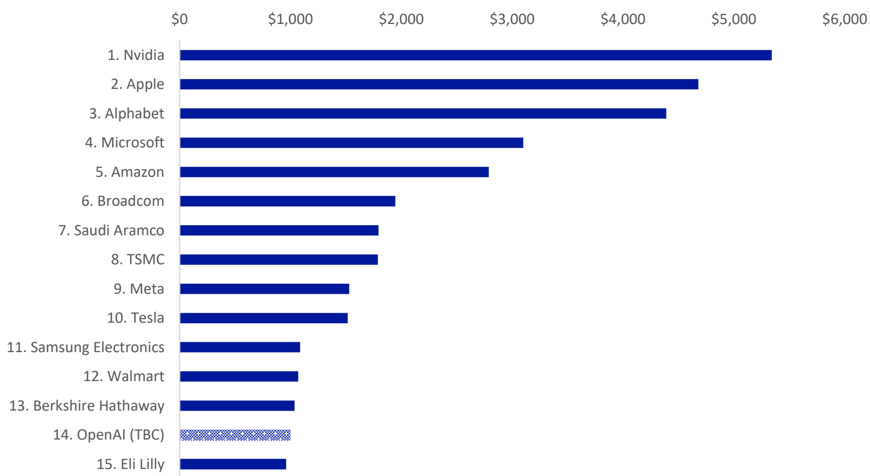
A trillion-dollar valuation would also make OpenAI, which has yet to make a profit and will reportedly make $30bn in annualised revenue this month, the 14th biggest company in the world by market capitalisation.

That would be just behind Berkshire Hathaway, which made revenues of over $370bn and net earnings attributable to shareholders of $67bn last year, and just ahead of Eli Lilly, whose sales topped $65bn and profit was $21bn.

The most valuable company is Nvidia, perhaps the nearest thing investors currently have to a large pure-play AI investment, whose shares have surged more than 13 times since the launch of ChatGPT to give it a market capitalisation of $5.4trn.

Figure 2: A $1trn valuation would make OpenAI the world's 14th biggest company ($bn)

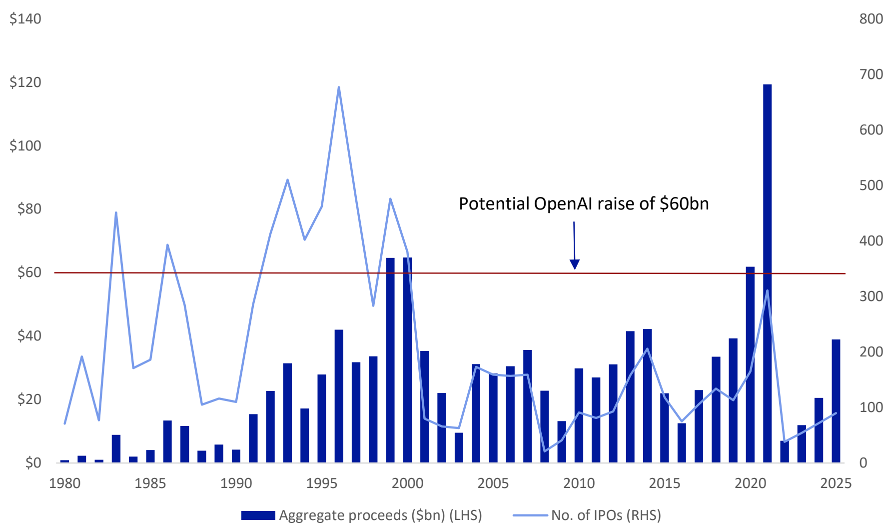


Source :Bloomberg Finance LP, Deutsche Bank Research

OpenAI is in a race with Anthropic, which overtook it in sales last month and is on track to generate $40bn in annual recurring revenue this month, according to data from The Information. The maker of Claude may be looking to raise more than $60bn in its own IPO this year, media reports say, even while it is simultaneously in talks with investors about raising cash at a valuation of $900bn – nudging it ahead of OpenAI.

A $60bn IPO would also be larger on its own than the total amount raised in US IPOs in all but four years since 1980, according to data from the University of Florida. It would barely fall short of the $65bn raised in both 1999 and 2000, and the $62bn raised in 2020, and would be half of the record-breaking $119bn raised in 2021.

Figure 3: A $60bn IPO would be just short of three of the four biggest years for US IPOs since 1980



Source : Jay Ritter, University of Florida, Deutsche Bank Research

While there may be concerns about the capacity of the market to absorb a number of IPOs valued at several hundred billion dollars this year, they would slot into an US stock market worth about $70trn overall. That is five times larger in nominal terms than it was even at the peak of the dot-com bubble in the late 1990s. At that time, there was an average of almost 500 IPOs a year, compared with about 120 this decade, and they are typically now coming to market at a more mature stage.

Last week, AI chipmaker Cerebras raised $6.4bn, including the overallotment option, in the largest IPO this year. The shares jumped by two thirds on its first day of trading, giving it a market value of roughly $67bn.

OpenAI has been preparing the groundwork for an IPO in recent months, streamlining its offering, focusing more on paying enterprise customers and clarifying its partnership with Microsoft. Earlier this week it won a long-running legal case brought by Elon Musk.

See the Deutsche Bank Research Institute for recent relevant research, including Will Claude's AI finance agents change your life? and AI, Iran and the Gulf 101. The website is available to all so feel free to share.

Appendix 1

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